

The Q4 Moment Menu

Build Your AI-Powered 90-Day Marketing Campaign for the Holidays Branches B1 · Facilitated by The Creative Strategist

Your 90 days run **Monday, September 28 through Thursday, December 31, 2026**. That is 95 days, about 13 and a half weeks.

You are not going to run a campaign for every date here. You are going to pick **three to five big moments**, and then use the **trend days** as easy, low-effort content in the gaps.

Everyone builds Thanksgiving. That is the anchor, Thursday, November 26. It is 8 and a half weeks out, so nobody here is behind.

Part 1: The Big Moments

These are the ones worth a real campaign: an offer, a flyer, a video, an email.

Moment	Date	Day
Halloween	October 31	Saturday
Veterans Day	November 11	Wednesday
Thanksgiving (your anchor)	November 26	Thursday
Black Friday	November 27	Friday
Small Business Saturday	November 28	Saturday
Cyber Monday	November 30	Monday
Giving Tuesday	December 1	Tuesday
Hanukkah	December 4 (sundown) to December 12	Friday to Saturday
Green Monday	December 14	Monday
Super Saturday	December 19	Saturday
Christmas	December 25	Friday
New Year's Eve	December 31	Thursday

Three things to notice.

Thanksgiving through Giving Tuesday is six days in a row. That is not six campaigns. That is one campaign with six doors.

Christmas is a Friday, so the last real shopping weekend is December 19 and 20, not the week of the 21st.

Hanukkah and Christmas barely overlap this year. Hanukkah ends December 12, almost two weeks before Christmas. If you serve Jewish families, that is a separate, earlier selling window, not a footnote on a Christmas post.

What each one is actually good for

Halloween · Saturday, October 31

Good for: anything visual, anything for families with kids, anything you can theme without discounting.

The play: this is your warm-up, not your money moment. Use it to find out which of your posts people actually respond to, four weeks before the stakes get high. **Small business version:** a barber posts four "Halloween fade" designs and lets people vote in the comments. Zero discount, real engagement, and now he knows what his audience responds to before Black Friday. **Skip it if:** nothing you do is visual and your customers are other businesses.

Veterans Day · Wednesday, November 11

Good for: any business that can offer something real to veterans and their families. **The play:** something specific, generous, and easy to claim. Not 10 percent off. Something that costs you a little and means a lot. **Small business version:** a landscaper does one free yard cleanup for a veteran family, nominated by the community in the comments. One job, and the post does more for him than a month of advertising. **Skip it if:** you cannot back it up. A hollow Veterans Day post is worse than silence.

Thanksgiving · Thursday, November 26 · YOUR ANCHOR

Good for: every business here, which is exactly why it is the anchor. **The play:** gratitude is the only message that works for every business type, in every industry, without a discount. You are not selling on Thanksgiving. You are thanking people, and you are setting up the four days that follow. **Small business version:** a hair salon posts a short video naming, out loud, the ten clients who have been with her the longest. No offer at all. Those ten people each shared it, and her Black Friday post two days later landed on a warm audience instead of a cold one. **Why we chose it:** the message is universal, the emotion is real, and it feeds straight into Black Friday weekend. Build this one well and the next four moments are a re-skin, not a rebuild.

Black Friday · Friday, November 27

Good for: product businesses, anything with inventory, anything you can bundle. **The play:** do not try to out-discount Amazon. You will lose. Win on the thing they cannot do: you know your customer's name. A small, personal, limited offer beats a big impersonal one. **Small business version:** a bakery does not discount at all. She offers "the first 20 orders get a free box of six cookies." Same revenue per order, the offer sells out by noon, and the scarcity is real. **Skip it if:** you are a premium service business where discounting damages what you have built. See the note at the end.

Small Business Saturday · Saturday, November 28

Good for: this is your day. Every single business in this room. **The play:** the entire national conversation that day is about choosing local over big. You do not have to create the reason to buy from you, it is already in the air. All you have to do is show up and be findable. **Small business version:** four neighboring shops on the same block make one shared flyer listing all four, and each one posts it. Four audiences, one piece of content, and every customer who walks into one hears about the other three. **Skip it if:** never. If you only run two moments this quarter, make them Thanksgiving and this one.

Cyber Monday · Monday, November 30

Good for: anything you sell online, digital products, services booked through a link, gift cards. **The play:** the online twin of Black Friday. If anyone can buy from you without standing in front of you, this is your moment. **Small business version:** a personal trainer who has no physical product at all sells 25 gift certificates for January sessions. Revenue in November, work in January, and every certificate is a new client walking in the door. **Skip it if:** everything you do happens in person and there is no online way to pay you.

Giving Tuesday · Tuesday, December 1

Good for: businesses with a cause, community roots, or a story about who you lift up. **The play:** tie a purchase to a contribution, or just contribute and say so plainly. **Small business version:** a coffee shop gives one dollar from every drink that day to the elementary school two blocks over, and puts a running tally on a chalkboard by the register. Customers came back the next day to see the number go up. **Skip it if:** you have no genuine cause connection. Manufacturing one for the day is transparent.

Hanukkah · Sundown Friday, December 4 through Saturday, December 12

Good for: any business serving Jewish families. Food, gifts, candles, photography, home goods, restaurants, and any service bought as a gift. **The play:** eight nights means eight days of gifting, which is a much longer window than one Christmas morning. Start before December 4, because people shop ahead. Get the details right: it is eight nights, gifts are often smaller and given nightly, and "Happy Hanukkah" is the greeting. **Small business version:** a gift shop builds one "eight small gifts" bundle at a

single price, one for each night, and it becomes her easiest sale of the season because it solves the whole problem in one purchase. **Skip it if:** you genuinely do not serve this community. But check before you assume, because most businesses in a diverse city do.

Green Monday · Monday, December 14

Good for: anything sold online that still has time to arrive before Christmas. **The play:** the last big online buying day where shipping still comfortably works. Most small businesses have never heard of it, which is exactly the opportunity: the inboxes are less crowded than Cyber Monday. **Small business version:** an online candle maker sends one email that says only "order by Wednesday and it is under the tree." Her highest-converting email of the year, and it took six minutes to write. **Skip it if:** you do not ship and you do not sell online.

Super Saturday · Saturday, December 19

Good for: almost everyone, and it is badly underused. **The play:** the last Saturday before Christmas, and the single biggest in-person shopping day of the season. These are panic buyers. They are not comparing, they are not negotiating, they want the problem solved today. **Small business version:** a florist posts one thing at 8am: "Open until 6. We have gifts ready to go. Walk in." No discount, no design work, just being visibly open and ready. It was her best single day of the year. **Skip it if:** you are closed that day. And consider not being closed that day.

Christmas · Friday, December 25

Good for: almost everyone, but the money is made in the three weeks before, not on the day. **The play:** two different campaigns hide in here. **Gift buyers** through December 20, then **panic buyers** December 21 to 24, who are a completely different person with a completely different problem. Gift cards and anything instant win the panic window. **Small business version:** a photographer sells "print at home" gift certificates from December 21. No shipping, no inventory, no production, and it captured every person who had left someone off their list. **Watch the calendar:** Christmas is a Friday, so the last real shopping weekend is December 19 and 20.

New Year's Eve · Thursday, December 31

Good for: anything about a fresh start. Fitness, coaching, organizing, beauty, education, financial services, home improvement. **The play:** this is where you sell January, in December. People buy the version of themselves they want to be next year. Start around December 26, when every competitor has stopped selling and the field is empty. **Small business version:** a bookkeeper posts one thing on December 27: "Books a mess? Let's start 2027 clean." She books out January in four days, because nobody else was talking. **Skip it if:** nothing you sell connects to starting over.

Part 2: Trend Days

These are **not campaigns**. They are single posts. Fifteen minutes each, no offer required, no flyer needed.

Their whole job is to keep you visible on the days between your big moments, so that when you do have something to sell, you are not a stranger showing up with a discount.

Pick the three or four that genuinely connect to what you do. Ignore the rest.

Day	Date 2026	Who it is for
International Coffee Day	Thu Oct 1	Cafés, bakeries, anyone with a morning ritual
National Dessert Day	Wed Oct 14	Bakers, restaurants, caterers
National Boss's Day	Fri Oct 16	Gift shops, flowers, B2B services, restaurants
Sweetest Day	Sat Oct 17	Anything gifted, sweets, flowers, salons
National Sandwich Day	Tue Nov 3	Delis, cafés, food trucks, caterers
World Kindness Day	Fri Nov 13	Every business. Costs nothing.
National Entrepreneurs Day	Tue Nov 17	Every business here. This one is about you.
National Espresso Day	Mon Nov 23	Cafés, and it lands three days before Thanksgiving
National Cookie Day	Fri Dec 4	Bakers. Also the first night of Hanukkah.
National Ugly Sweater Day	Fri Dec 18	Retail, salons, anywhere with a team and a camera

A note on accuracy. Most "national days" are informal, promoted by trade groups or registries rather than officially designated, and sources sometimes disagree on a date. The fixed-date ones above are stable. The floating ones (Sweetest Day, Entrepreneurs Day, Ugly Sweater Day) are calculated from their usual rule. If you plan to build anything significant around one of these, search it the week before to confirm.

How to use a trend day in fifteen minutes

1. Take a photo on your phone of the thing, or of you, or of your team.
2. Write two sentences. One about the day, one about you.
3. Post it. No offer, no link, no design work.
4. Done. Move on.

Small business version: an auto shop posts on National Entrepreneurs Day: a photo of the owner's father, who opened the shop in 1994, next to a photo of him standing in the same doorway today. Two sentences. It was the most-shared thing he posted all year, and he did not sell anything.

That is the point. Trend days build the trust. Big moments collect on it.

How to choose: the filter

Not every date is right for every business. Most are right for most. Run each one through these four questions and be honest:

1. **Does my customer actually care about this date?** Not do I. Do they.
2. **Can I deliver if it works?** A campaign that sells more than you can make loses you a customer instead of winning one.
3. **Do I have the lead time?** Count backward. If you need two weeks to make something and the date is in ten days, that date is not available to you.
4. **Is this authentically mine?** Borrowed occasions read as hollow, and your regulars will feel it.

Three to five big moments. Three or four trend days. Not everything. A campaign you run beats a calendar you admire.

If you cannot discount

If you are a premium or service business, discounting in Q4 can do damage that follows you into next year. You have other moves:

- **Add instead of subtract.** Same price, more value. A bonus session, a small gift, faster delivery.
 - **Bundle.** Two things together at a price that is fair but not cut.
 - **Early access.** Your regulars get first look. Costs you nothing, feels like a lot.
 - **Close the door.** A limited number and a real deadline. Scarcity beats discount for premium brands.
 - **Opt out loudly.** Some businesses have built real goodwill by publicly refusing to run a Black Friday sale and saying why. It works when it is genuinely who you are.
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Your pick

Big moments (choose three to five)

- ☐ Halloween, Oct 31
- ☐ Veterans Day, Nov 11
- ☒ **Thanksgiving, Nov 26 (anchor, everyone)**
- ☐ Black Friday, Nov 27

- ☐ Small Business Saturday, Nov 28
- ☐ Cyber Monday, Nov 30
- ☐ Giving Tuesday, Dec 1
- ☐ Hanukkah, Dec 4 to 12
- ☐ Green Monday, Dec 14
- ☐ Super Saturday, Dec 19
- ☐ Christmas, Dec 25
- ☐ New Year's Eve, Dec 31
- ☐ Something else that matters to my business: _____

Trend days (choose three or four)

- ☐ Intl Coffee Day, Oct 1
- ☐ Dessert Day, Oct 14
- ☐ Boss's Day, Oct 16
- ☐ Sweetest Day, Oct 17
- ☐ Sandwich Day, Nov 3
- ☐ Kindness Day, Nov 13
- ☐ Entrepreneurs Day, Nov 17
- ☐ Espresso Day, Nov 23
- ☐ Cookie Day, Dec 4
- ☐ Ugly Sweater Day, Dec 18
- ☐ A day that matters in my industry: _____

Dates that matter only to my business

Your anniversary, a founding date, a seasonal peak, a local event, a festival, a game day, a school calendar. These are often worth more than any national holiday, because nobody else is using them.

1.

2.

3.

Next: take your picks into Module 2 on the resource hub and generate your Q4 Moment Map.

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